



THE LONDON SCHOOL  
OF ECONOMICS AND  
POLITICAL SCIENCE ■

# WEEK FOUR

## LN905 Academic Writing & Assignment



### Assignment Task: Submitting a Draft



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## Lesson One: Making Claims (Hedging/Boosting)

### 1. What is a claim?

### 2. Look at the examples below. Which claim is more appropriate and why?

*Example One:*

*100 Media students, from a cohort of 120, were interviewed and 93 said that they had enjoyed their first term at LSE.*

**Claim 1:** This **seems to indicate** that the Media department has, **to some extent at least**, a **relatively popular** programme of courses in the first term.

**Claim 2:** This **clearly shows** that the Media department has a popular programme of courses in the first term.

*Example Two:*

*Based on the interviews I conducted with two Chinese students, ...*

**Claim 1:** ...it **might be** the case that some Chinese students **show a slight preference** for writing in English when compared to speaking.

**Claim 2:** ...I have **proved** that Chinese students prefer writing in English to speaking.

### 3. Arrange the following words into the two columns below:

|                   |                           |            |                     |
|-------------------|---------------------------|------------|---------------------|
| Suggest           | May                       | Seem       | Appear              |
| Could             | Might                     | Assume     | Certain/Certainly   |
| Demonstrate       | Plainly                   | Likely     | Definite/Definitely |
| Possible/Possibly | Doubtless                 | Speculate  | Indicate            |
| Probable/Probably | Seemingly                 | Supposedly | Show that           |
| The fact that     | Substantial/Substantially |            | Clear/Clearly       |
| Unmistakable      | Evidently                 | In fact    |                     |

| Hedging Expressions | Boosting Expressions |
|---------------------|----------------------|
|                     |                      |

### 4. Highlight the claims made in this paragraph:

Over the next 25 years, the U.S. economy is likely to experience significant shifts driven by several key factors. Technological advancements, particularly in artificial intelligence, automation, and clean energy, are expected to transform industries, leading to increased productivity but also potential disruptions in the labour market. Demographic changes, including an aging population and shifting immigration patterns, could strain social safety nets and impact workforce dynamics. Climate change and the transition to a more sustainable economy will require substantial investments and may reshape sectors such as energy, agriculture, and infrastructure. Additionally, the global economic landscape will influence U.S. economic policies, as competition with emerging economies, particularly China and India, intensifies. Economic inequality may remain a central challenge, potentially influencing policy debates and social stability. Overall, while the U.S. economy is likely to remain resilient, it will need to navigate these complex challenges to ensure sustained growth and prosperity.

### 5. Improve the claims made in these sentences:

1. Universities' only purpose is to equip graduates for the workplace.
2. Obviously, universities must increase tuition fees.
3. There is no doubt that social media is extremely damaging to mental health.
4. Social media is fantastic for social cohesion.
5. Gender inequality is evil.
6. No men recognise their historical privilege.
7. Everyone is worried about the fact that there are too many people in the world.
8. Depopulation is a greater concern than overpopulation

## Findings & Claims

### 6. Read the following and highlight language that:

- a. Report **findings** from research which the author conducted
- b. Makes **claims** based on the research
- c. Uses language to show how certain the writer is about the claims (hedging/boosting)

Women reporting high levels of managerial support were less likely to experience strain as a result of work interference with home than were women reporting lower levels of support.<sup>1</sup> This finding supports previous research by O'Driscoll *et al.* (2003),<sup>2</sup>

who found that the effect of work interference with home on psychological strain was moderated by work- home related supervisor support.<sup>3</sup> Managers who offer emotional and/or instrumental support for their employees' work-home concerns appear able to reduce the extent to which their subordinates – at least, their female subordinates - suffer strain arising from the interference of work demands with their responsibilities at home.<sup>4</sup> An employee whose long work hours are interfering with her ability to spend time with friends or family is liable to experience less strain when management appears supportive and willing to help than when management is perceived as uncaring and not interested in employees' lives beyond the workplace.<sup>5</sup> This effect did not take place for men,<sup>6</sup> suggesting that they are less responsive to this type of support.<sup>7</sup> This is perhaps due to gender norms stipulating independence for men, and discouraging them from seeking or accepting assistance from others (Helgeson, 2005).<sup>8</sup>

**Extra Time:**

Work on your assignment; check your hedging and boosting accurately reflects the strength of the claim.

## Lesson Two: Passive

Using **active** or **passive** is not about which is better or more interesting or more academic, but which is more appropriate. They are not in competition; they do different jobs.

**Task 1:** The sentences below are all **active**. With some classmates, rewrite them into the passive. Then: 1) decide if they are more suitable in the active or the passive, and 2) if passive, is it better to include the agent or not?

- 1) Scientists will soon develop a vaccination for the Ebola virus.
- 2) Many politicians continue to debate the costs and necessity of net zero.
- 3) This essay will analyse the key challenges facing governments about engaging citizens with climate change.
- 4) Academics are unable to reach a consensus about on definition of intersectionality.

**Task 2:** The choice of using active or passive can be made depending on what you want to focus on: in the below, are the events/ideas more important, or are the people/agents involved? Why?

- 1) *The vaccine was approved after extensive clinical trials.*
- 2) *The Bank of England raised interest rates in response to inflation.*
- 3) *Global temperatures have risen by over 1°C since pre-industrial levels.*
- 4) *Local residents opposed the development on environmental grounds.*
- 5) *Researchers at LSE identified several important trends.*
- 6) *The proposal was rejected on cost grounds.*

**Task 3:** Below are two paragraphs, one active and one passive. Which is more suitable & why? What other uses of passive can you see?

### Example 1:

#### passive style

Biosecurity is defined as a set of measures to protect animals and crops from the risk of disease. It is considered important in pig production, and several routine measures are employed by farmers (e.g. cleaning, disinfection, segregation). However, air as a potential vector of pathogens has long been disregarded. Filters for incoming and recirculating air were installed into the ventilation system of one of two barns at a fattening piggery. Over three consecutive fattening periods, the lung health of pigs in the filtered compared with the unfiltered barn was evaluated. Air filtration was easily introduced into the existing ventilation system. Better lung health was found in animals from the barn equipped with recirculating air filtration modules. Therefore, air filtration systems in animal rearing enclosures should be recommended by animal healthcare professionals.

### **Example 2: active style**

I define Biosecurity as a set of measures to protect animals and crops from the risk of disease. It is important in pig production, and farmers routinely employ several measures (e.g. cleaning, disinfection, segregation). However, experts have long disregarded air as a potential vector of pathogens. I installed filters for incoming and recirculating air into the ventilation system of one of two barns at a fattening piggery. Over three consecutive fattening periods, I compared the lung health of pigs in the filtered and unfiltered barn. It was easy for me to introduce air filtration into the existing ventilation system. Animals had better lung health in the barn equipped with recirculating air filtration modules. Therefore, animal healthcare professionals should recommend air filtration systems in animal rearing enclosures.

*(Adapted from: Wenke C. et al. (2018). Impact of different supply air and recirculating air filtration systems on stable climate, animal health, and performance of fattening pigs in a commercial pig farm. PloS One 13.3: e0194641)*

**Task 4:** How often do passives appear in a paragraph? Look at the below before we discuss. This was written by an LSE student; some passives have been highlighted. Think about 1) Where they are, and 2) Why has passive been used.

Such influential potential of ICT *is also captured by* the concepts of functional simplification and closure. In contrast to the dominant literature, which focuses on instrumental terms, i.e. how technology helps to accomplish certain ends, this approach views technology as a structuring agent that supports human actions (Kallinikos, 2005). On the one hand, functional simplification involves the isolation of an operational domain, within which reality's complexity is simplified into a set of causal relationships. Although these relations can themselves be quite complex, the initial reduction of the inputs tends to make the system controllable. By further specifying how the technology handles the individual elements of this domain, it helps human actors deal with reality. The intricacies of the contemporary world *are therefore broken down* into piecemeal parts and their relationships to each other, i.e. the technology creates structure. On the other hand, functional closure refers to "the construction of a protective cocoon that is placed around the selected causal sequences or processes to safeguard undesired interference and ensure their recurrent unfolding" (Kallinikos, 2005, p. 190). Thus, the technological system is black-boxed and decoupled from other organisational and social spheres. Social interaction with the technology is highly limited to those with special skills, training and roles. Consequently, ICT *can be seen* as a regulative power that structures social and organisational interactions (Bovens and Zouridis, 2002; Kallinikos, 2005; Cordella and Tempini, 2015) as well as shapes the outcome of legislative processes (Contini and Mohr, 2014; Cordella and Gualdi, 2019).

**Task 5:** Passive it-clauses are useful for 1) removing the need for personal pronouns, but also 2) hedging, 3) introducing ideas (such as for topic sentences) and 4) drawing conclusions (such as in concluding sentences).

Complete the following – add some adverbs also, if appropriate:

| <b>We can see that...</b> | <b>= It can be seen that...</b> |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------|
| We discovered (that)...   | =                               |
| Everybody knows (that)... | =                               |
| I recommend (that)...     | =                               |
| I argue (that)...         | =                               |
| You can assume (that)...  | =                               |
| People think (that)...    | =                               |

## Lesson Three: Nominalisation

**Task 1:** Which of the following texts looks more 'academic' to you? Why?

Version 1:

The rise of global temperature has resulted in a marked increase of the extinction of animal species. Despite scepticism from a small number of powerful individuals, the complexity and urgency of the problems must be addressed immediately before it is too late. Wild habitat redevelopment is paramount to allow space for animal population reproduction and recovery.

Version 2:

With global temperatures rising, there has been a marked increase of animal species becoming extinct. Despite sceptical views from a small number of powerful individuals, the problems faced are complex and urgent, and must be addressed immediately before it is too late. Redeveloping the wild habitats is paramount to allow space for the animal populations to reproduce and recover.

**Task 2:** Use the verbs below to complete the paragraph below with suitable noun forms.

The \_\_\_\_\_ of life has been driven in part by \_\_\_\_\_ in the physical environment. No single kind of living thing can perform well in all environments. The differences among living things that enable them to live in different kinds of environments and adopt different lifestyles are called \_\_\_\_\_.

For a long period of time, there was no life on Earth. Then there was an extended period of only uni-cellular life, followed by a \_\_\_\_\_ of multi-cellular life. In other words, the nature and diversity of life has changed over time. \_\_\_\_\_ of the processes that result in biological \_\_\_\_\_ was one of the great scientific advances of the nineteenth century.

*adapt      vary      evolve      proliferate      identify      diversify*

### *Reporting*

**Task 3:** With a partner, rewrite the following sentences using nominalisation – the words you should nominalise are highlighted in bold. You may need to restructure the sentence.

1: Global temperatures continue to **rise** rapidly, a trend that scientists consider deeply **concerning**.

2: Individuals frequently **assume** that climate change is too **complex** and **remote** to affect them personally. Therefore, many **fail** to act.

3: Because scientists have observed the **atmosphere's carbon dioxide** levels **increasing rapidly**, they are recommending that emissions be cut **urgently**.

4: Governments have not **communicated** the risks clearly, so the public does not **understand** that acting is **urgent**.

5: In order to **reduce** global **emissions successfully**, it is essential for governments to **invest** in **renewable energy rapidly**.

6: The media rarely **explains** why climate policies **fail**, which makes the public more **sceptical**.

## Lesson Four: Writing Concisely

### Ways to write concisely

a) Avoid redundant words/expressions

- The results are highly significant and important.
- The results are significant.

b) Use specific vocabulary

- Many people who write academic articles in this field consider the issue to be vital.
- Scholars consider the issue to be vital.

c) Avoid multiple word constructions (where less wordy ones exist).

- In considering and assessing the overall need for a new policy, it is necessary to deeply evaluate a wide range of options.

A wide range of options should be considered.

c) Avoid passive constructions (where appropriate)

- It has been said by Jones (2023) that the result of the UK election was influenced by Sunak's weak performance in debates.
- Jones (2023) has argued that Sunak's weak debate performance influenced the UK election.

e) Consider the use of adjectives instead of relative clauses or complements (where possible)

- The LSE, which was founded in 1895 and which is generally viewed as a leading university, is now one of the UK's most important educational institutions.
- Founded in 1895, the LSE is a leading UK university.

- f) Do not include “obvious” information
- The poor weather in winter in some Scandinavian countries means that buildings are generally well-heated when it is cold.
  - Buildings in Scandinavian countries are well-heated in winter.

- g) Do not include unnecessary examples
- There are many excellent universities in the UK, for example, Oxford, Cambridge, LSE, UCL, Manchester.
  - There are many excellent universities in the UK.

**Task 1:** All these sentences are too wordy. Can you cut them down?

1. Trouble is caused when employees disobey rules that have been established for the safety of all.
2. This essay will attempt to examine the work of Rothe (2005), as well as the work of Peterson (2005), comparing and contrasting these positive views on HRC theory with the opposing views of Smith (2006).
3. It is expected that the new restructuring will be announced by the board of managers within the next few days.
4. Some people passionately believe in Brexit, while other people are against it: there is much disagreement on this subject.
5. The data is represented in the bar chart (Figure 3.4) below:
6. In spite of the fact that in-house training programmes can be very easily organised by most human resource managers, there are often few such programmes in major companies.
7. A great number of people feel that people who work for the government need to be able to communicate with the public in a more effective way.

8. In order to answer the question, it is necessary for me to research this topic further.
9. Could you recommend to us someone in the area who works as a contractor?
10. The problem was addressed at our meeting that we have every week.
11. Carlos speaks English fluently, and can also speak Portuguese at an intermediate level, and in addition he is capable of conversing in German.
12. Some people passionately believe in Brexit, while other people are passionately against it: there is much disagreement on this subject.

**Task 2:** Can you make the following text more concise.

International relations are an extremely important and essential aspect of citizenship in a global society. As the world is becoming smaller and smaller through the ever expanding and ubiquitous use of communication technology, rapid air transportation and the working of the complex international economy, the value of peaceful, cooperative and harmonious relationships between the nations on this planet is becoming increasingly important. When the whole international community confronts nuclear weapons proliferation, terrorism, poverty, climate change (i.e., global warming) and epidemic diseases (e.g. AIDS) it is necessary for national interests to obtain multilateral agreements and pursue actions to deal with threats, challenges or problems that cannot be dealt with effectively at the unilateral level

**Now read through your assignment and consider how you can make your writing more concise.**